From Far Around They Saw Us Burn

By Alice Jolly

We are the children of Cavan. Do you know of that place? It is a border town, betwixt and between, a place of crossroads--and yet strangely few pass by there. Walking the main street, you pass the Central Hotel and Sullivans the General Store. And then, of course, the Convent buildings and the orphanage.

Those buildings are there and yet they are not. For that place is never opened up, the nuns being a closed order, so though many windows face onto the street, the glass obscured by bars. We orphanage girls are never seen. And should you ever have cause to knock, the nun who unlocks the door will keep to the side so that you may not see her, for that is the way of our world.

INTRODUCTION

St. Joseph's Orphanage and Industrial School, the institution once run by the Poor Clare Sisters in Cavan town, has largely been forgotten; but it outraged the whole

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of Ireland over 70 years ago after a terrible fire broke out in the basement laundry in the early hours of a February morning in 1943.

Incredibly, when alerted to the gathering smoke by an orphan girl, a senior nun made the decision not to evacuate the children, instead she directed them to the top floor dormitory and closed the doors. Thirty-five children burned to death. The nuns survived.

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It was the Sullivan family who knew of it first -- smoke, smoke, pumping out of a vent in the orphanage wall. We orphanage girls felt it first as a settling of boards, the scraping of a hinge, a sound like a yawn, a taste of ash. But we were feared to get up. We lay rigid in our beds. Ten to two.

Suddenly, the lights came on and we all stood blinking in our white night dresses, standing between the six rows of iron beds.

Later, it was recorded that it was Cissie Reilly started banging. For how else could they wake the sleeping nuns and alert them to the danger? Then John McNally was kicking with stout boots.

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Get the children out. Do you not see? The fire is spreading. But a nun said ***No, no. It is the fire in the laundry which must be put out***. So a group of them ran to the laundry door but it was locked. The nuns said, ***You must wait for the key.*** But the men knew better and kicked it in.

We girls were waiting in the dormitory, our hands knotted together, the little ones silent and hollow-eyed. When Miss O'Reilly came in, she was not at all fussed. She said, ***Get down on your knees and pray. Say an Act of Contrition.***

Some of us then crowded to the window. From there we saw a group of had gone into the infirmary and were carrying out the babies. Then the door burst open, and girls started pouring out, their white night dresses swelling as they ran. A girl burst out, and the soles of her feet were burning. She ran screaming across the courtyard, her arms waving, her eyes rolling. Screaming and screaming, her feet blazing fire.

My sister, my sister. I must get her down. That shout came from Kathleen, looking for Bernadette. Other voices came up from down the wooden stairs. Then banging and

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coughing, a sound of choking. But no one came up the stairs, only a wall of smoke.

We said to each other ***We must pray.*** But we could think of no prayers. ***We need to have air. We need to have air.***

Then suddenly all was dark -- We heard a door breaking somewhere close and a rush of air, which pushed the smoke further upon us. We were blown back into the room by the force of it. All below was alight. *Blessed Mary have mercy on us.*

[It was] forty feet up to our dormitory. We knew we were trapped. Ladders were the only hope. We opened the windows and bashed on the sections which did not give. Sparks, fire balls, and pieces of slate were raining down.

Then a girl jumped, rising up first, so it seemed, like some great white bird, then dipping down, falling faster and faster through the air. Even the blankets spread out below could not break her fall.

Some of us sat on the beds and gathered the smaller children around us. ***Hail Mary, full of Grace, the Lord is with thee. Pray for us sinners now and at the hour of our***

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death. Dear Lord, we were trying. But the little children were all screaming.

We heard a rush and crash as the wooden stairs below us collapsed. The window was burning hot. The glass cracking, blowing out, melting down. The floor started to go. Wardrobes and beds disappeared into the furnace. One girl was lying unconscious on her bed, the clothes on her back on fire. Then she disappeared. Only those of us on the windowsill now were left. The men were calling up: *Come on, girl. Come on. Jump. Jump.* It was too far down.

Praise God a man came with a ladder. He put out his hands and pulled some of us off, placing us on the ladder so that we might get down. But when it came to the turn of Bernadette, who was but seven years old, she tried to go back into the room, such was her terror. Theresa went after her and got hold of her by the hair, dragged her toward the man on the ladder so that he got her down. Though by then Bernadette's back and hair were flaming. As he came down, flames smashed out through the window above. A roar, a heaving, a smash of timbers. The time was 2.40 a.m.

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The next day, the orphanage was nothing but a burnt-out frame -- damp wisps of smoke curling out through the debris. Only the many iron beds could you see still standing, stuck up in curved shapes, like the rib cages of so many skeleton beasts. All the businesses in the town were closed and a sickening smell spread all about.

It was not until darkness was falling that all the bodies were brought out. The men shouldered the coffins and took them to the Convent chapel, laid them down near the altar. Thirty-five girls but only eight coffins.

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Later, we were asked--those of us who still had tongues to speak--about what happened. We were asked again and again: ***You knew the instructions in case of a fire, so why did you not follow those procedures?*** **Yet** that question was never asked of the nuns.

It was said, ***many of those orphan girls are simple.*** But we were not simple, we were frightened. Mother Carmel would strip your clothes from your body, beat you skinless.

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Questions were asked about the fire escape. It was but seven foot away from the dormitory, so why were the children not able to get out? And the lights in the building, why were they switched off? Miss O'Reilly was questioned at some length. ***Was there not a full fifteen minutes during which those children could have been brought down?*** **In** the town it was whispered, ***It was because those girls must not be seen in their nightdresses by the men of the town.*** All of the nuns safe enough, so God be praised.

Many years have passed now. It was long ago. But we are still waiting. We are the children of Cavan. Have you heard speak of us? From all around they saw us burn but none could help. It was discipline and fear which killed us [they said], not the wire in the laundry clothes dryer.

We are still waiting at the window. Please, will you bring the ladder up to us? Or must we run to heaven with our feet on fire?

We are the children of Cavan. From all around they saw us burn . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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This story is based on documents and personal testimony relating to the fire at St. Josephs orphanage in Cavan on the night of February 23,1943.

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